

Levantine Arabic Verb Conjugation

Past, Present & Future Tenses with Modifiers

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What is Levantine Arabic?

- Spoken dialect in Syria, Lebanon, Jordan, and Palestine
- Different from Modern Standard Arabic (MSA) - the everyday spoken language
- Simplified verb system compared to MSA
- No dual form (only singular and plural)
- No grammatical case endings
- Rich in regional variations but mutually intelligible
- Uses a root-and-pattern system like all Arabic varieties

Levantine Arabic Verb Basics

- Most verbs built on a 3-consonant root (e.g., k-t-b = write)
- Conjugation changes based on: person, number, gender, and tense
- Two main tenses: Past (perfect) and Present (imperfect)
- Future formed by adding prefix to present tense
- Subject pronouns often dropped (verb shows the subject)
- Example root: ك-ت-ب (k-t-b) meaning 'to write'

Subject Pronouns Reference

Person	Arabic	Transliteration	English
1st Singular	أنا	ana	I
2nd Sing. Masc.	انت	inta	you (m)
2nd Sing. Fem.	انتى	inti	you (f)
3rd Sing. Masc.	هو	huwwe	he
3rd Sing. Fem.	هى	hiyye	she
1st Plural	نحن	niḥna	we
2nd Plural	وتن	intu	you (pl)
3rd Plural	هم	hunne	they

Past Tense (يضا م لا)

- Used for completed actions in the past
- Formed by adding suffixes to the verb stem
- The stem itself doesn't change - only the endings
- Example verb: كاتب (katab) - 'to write'
- Past tense is the 'base' form of the verb
- Suffixes indicate person, number, and gender

Past Tense Conjugation

Person	Suffix	بَتَك (write)	Transliteration	Meaning
I	-t	تَبَتَك	katabt	I wrote
you (m)	-t	تَبَتَك	katabt	you wrote (m)
you (f)	-ti	يَتَبَتَك	katabti	you wrote (f)
he	-Ø	بَتَك	katab	he wrote
she	-et	تَبَتَك	kabet	she wrote
we	-na	اَنَبَتَك	kabna	we wrote
you (pl)	-tu	وَتَبَتَك	kabtu	you wrote (pl)
they	-u	وَبَتَك	kabu	they wrote

Note: 'I' and 'you (m)' have the same form - context clarifies meaning

Present Tense (عروض ملأ)

- Used for ongoing actions, habits, and general truths
- Formed with prefixes (and sometimes suffixes)
- The verb stem changes - vowel pattern differs from past
- Prefix 'b-' (bi-) added for indicative present in Levantine
- Without 'b-': subjunctive mood (after certain particles)
- Example: بكتب (baktub) - 'I write / I am writing'

Present Tense Conjugation

Person	Prefix	بَتَك (write)	Transliteration	Meaning
I	b-	بَتَكُب	baktub	I write
you (m)	bt-	بَتَكْتُب	btiktub	you write (m)
you (f)	bt-...-i	بَتَكْتُبِي	btiktubi	you write (f)
he	bi-	بَتَكِيْب	byiktub	he writes
she	bt-	بَتَكْتُب	btiktub	she writes
we	mn-	بَتَكْنَم	mniktub	we write
you (pl)	bt-...-u	وَبَتَكْتُب	btiktubu	you write (pl)
they	bi-...-u	وَبَتَكِيْب	byiktubu	they write

Note: 'you (m)' and 'she' have the same form

Future Tense (لـ ب ق ت س م ل ا)

- Formed by adding a prefix to the present tense (without 'b-')
- Main future marker: حـ (raḥ) or هـ (ḥa-)
- حـ is more common in Levantine dialects
- Can also use لـ (laḥ) in some regions
- The verb conjugation follows present tense patterns
- Example: حـ ب ت ك أ (raḥ aktub) - 'I will write'

Future Tense Conjugation

Person	Future Form	Transliteration	Meaning
I	بَتَكْتُأ حَر	raḥ aktub	I will write
you (m)	بَتَكْتُت حَر	raḥ tiktub	you will write (m)
you (f)	يَبَتَكْتُت حَر	raḥ tiktubi	you will write (f)
he	بَتَكْتُي حَر	raḥ yiktub	he will write
she	بَتَكْتُت حَر	raḥ tiktub	she will write
we	بَتَكُنْ حَر	raḥ niktub	we will write
you (pl)	وَبَتَكْتُت حَر	raḥ tiktubu	you will write (pl)
they	وَبَتَكْتُي حَر	raḥ yiktubu	they will write

Note: حَر (raḥ) stays the same for all persons

Modifiers in Levantine Arabic

- Modifiers change the meaning or mood of verbs
- Key modifiers include:
 - - Negation (making verbs negative)
 - - Question formation
 - - Continuous/Progressive aspect
 - - Habitual aspect
 - - Imperative (commands)
- Each modifier has specific rules for each tense

Negation (يـفنـلـا)

Tense	Negation Pattern	Example	Meaning
Past	ام + verb	تبتك ام	I didn't write
Present	ام + verb (no b-)	بتك ب ام	I don't write
Present (alt)	شم + b-verb	بتك ب شم	I don't write
Future	حر شم + verb	بتك أ حر شم	I won't write
Future (alt)	حر ام + verb	بتك أ حر ام	I won't write

ام (ma) and شم (mish) are both used for negation

Negation Details

- ام (ma) - General negation particle
- Past: تبتك ام (ma katabt) - 'I didn't write'
- Present: بتك ب ام (ma baktub) - 'I don't write'
- شم (mish) - Also means 'not', often for emphasis
- شم أكتب (mish raḥ aktub) - 'I will not write'
- In some dialects: ش...ام wraps around verb
- شتبتك ام (ma katabtish) - 'I didn't write' (Egyptian influence)

Question Formation (ماهفت سوال)

- Yes/No questions: Rising intonation (no word change needed)
- تبتك؟ (katabt?) - 'Did you write?'
- Question words placed at beginning:
- وش (shu) - what: تبتك وش 'What did you write?'
- شيل (lesh) - why: تبتك شيل 'Why did you write?'
- فيك (kif) - how: تبتك فيك 'How did you write?'
- نيو (wen) - where: تبتك نيو 'Where did you write?'
- ىتميا (emta) - when: تبتك ىتميا 'When did you write?'

Progressive Aspect (مع)

- مع ('am) indicates ongoing action 'right now'
- Added before present tense verb (without b-)
- Similar to English '-ing' forms
- Examples:
- مع بتكتب ('am baktub) - 'I am writing (right now)'
- مع بتكتب ('am yiktub) - 'He is writing'
- Can combine with ناك for past progressive:
- مع بتكتب ناك (kunt 'am baktub) - 'I was writing'

Using ناك (was/were)

Structure	Example	Transliteration	Meaning
ناك + past	بتك ناك	kān katab	he had written
ناك + b-present	بتكّي ب ناك	kān byiktub	he used to write
ناك + مع + present	بتكّي مع ناك	kān ‘am yiktub	he was writing
ناك + حر + present	بتكّي حر ناك	kān raḥ yiktub	he was going to write

ناك conjugates: تنك (I was), ناك (he was), تناك (she was), انك (we were)...

Imperative / Commands (رُمَألَا)

Person	Pattern	Example (write!)	Meaning
you (m. sing)	verb stem	بَتَكَا (ktub)	Write!
you (f. sing)	verb stem + i	بَتَكَاي (ktubi)	Write! (f)
you (plural)	verb stem + u	وَبَتَكَا (ktubu)	Write! (pl)

Negative command: ال + present (no b-): بَتَكَايْت ال (la tiktub) 'Don't write!'

Common Verbs - All Tenses

Verb	Past (he)	Present (he)	Future (he)
to go	حار (rāḥ)	حوريب (birūḥ)	حوري ح (raḥ yrūḥ)
to eat	أكأ (akal)	أكايب (byākul)	أكاي ح (raḥ yākul)
to see	فاش (shāf)	فوشيپ (bishūf)	فوشي ح (raḥ yshūf)
to speak	أكح (ḥaka)	أكحيپ (byiḥki)	أكحي ح (raḥ yiḥki)
to come	أكإ (ija)	أكجيپ (bīji)	أكجي ح (raḥ yīji)
to know	فرع ('irif)	فرعيب (bya'rif)	فرعي ح (raḥ ya'rif)
to want	أكوب (biddo)*	أكوب (biddo)	—

*أكوب is a pseudo-verb that conjugates differently: أكوب، أكوب، أكوب...

Verb Patterns (انازوالا)

- Levantine uses derived verb patterns (Forms I-X)
- Form I: Basic (لَعَف) - كَتَبَ (katab) 'write'
- Form II: Intensive/Causative (لَّعَف) - دَرَّسَ (darras) 'teach'
- Form III: Reciprocal (لَعَفَا) - سَاعَدَ (sā'ad) 'help'
- Form V: Reflexive of II (لَّعَفَت) - تَعَلَّمَ (t'allam) 'learn'
- Form VI: Reciprocal (لَعَفَات) - تَكَلَّمَ (tkallam) 'speak'
- Form VII: Passive (لَعَفْنَا) - كَسَرَ (nkasar) 'be broken'
- Each pattern conjugates similarly but with different vowels

Regional Variations

- Syrian: Uses ح/ج for future; soft pronunciation
- Lebanese: Similar to Syrian; French loanwords common
- Palestinian: Uses ح/ج; sometimes ح; glottal stops preserved
- Jordanian: Bedouin influences; ق often becomes گ [g]
- All are mutually intelligible with minor differences
- This presentation uses general Levantine forms
- Local variations in vocabulary and some conjugations exist

Quick Reference Summary

Tense	Formation	Example	Negation
Past	Stem + suffix	تبتك (katabt)	تبتك ام
Present	b- + prefix + stem	بتكب (baktub)	بتكب ام
Future	ح + present (no b-)	بتكأ ح (rah aktub)	بتكأ ح ش م
Progressive	مع + present	بتكب مع ('am baktub)	بتكب مع ام
Command	Stem only	بتك (ktub)	بتكت ال

Tips for Learning

- Master the pronouns and their corresponding verb endings first
- Learn verbs in groups with the same pattern
- Practice with common verbs: باج، يكح، فاش، لكأ، حار
- Listen to Levantine media (Syrian/Lebanese dramas, music)
- Focus on the 'b-' prefix pattern - it's essential for present tense
- Remember: Context often clarifies ambiguous forms
- Start with Form I verbs before learning derived forms
- قيفوتلاب! (Good luck!)

أراك ش!

Thank you for learning Levantine Arabic!

Questions?